

Patient Counseling: Thrombolytics for Acute Ischemic Stroke

What is a thrombolytic?

A **thrombolytic** is a medication used to **dissolve a blood clot** that is blocking blood flow to the brain during a stroke. You may hear it called a “**clot buster.**”

Common Questions & Key Talking Points

Why do I need this medicine?

- You are having a **stroke caused by a blood clot.**
- This medication helps **restore blood flow** to your brain.
- It can **improve your chance of recovery**, especially if given early.

Time is brain – the sooner we give it, the better the chances of preventing permanent brain damage.

Is it safe?

- It has been **well studied and approved** for this use.
- Like all strong medications, it comes with some **risks**, including **bleeding**.

What is the main risk?

- The biggest risk is **bleeding in the brain**, also called **hemorrhagic transformation**.
- Based on studies, this happens in about **5 out of every 100 patients** who get this medicine.
- While serious, we only use this medication when the **benefit outweighs the risk**.

What happens after I get the medication?

- You will go to a **special area like the ICU or stroke unit** for **very close monitoring**.
- We will:
 - Check your **blood pressure** frequently
 - Watch for **any signs of bleeding**
 - Limit needle sticks or procedures that could cause bleeding
 - Perform regular **neurologic exams**

Can I move around after the medicine?

- Not right away — we'll ask you to **rest in bed** while we monitor your brain and body closely.
- Movement and activities will be limited until we're sure it's safe.

Will I feel the medicine working?

- Some people notice **improvement quickly**, while others may improve more slowly.
- Not everyone gets full recovery — but this medication gives you the **best possible chance**.

What if I was on a blood thinner before this?

- That's something we check very carefully before giving this medication.
- If you are **on blood thinners**, we may need **labs or imaging first**, or we may choose another treatment.

Why was my loved one not given this medicine?

- Not all patients are eligible. Some reasons might be:
 - Too much time has passed since symptoms started

- Uncontrolled high blood pressure
- History of bleeding, surgery, or trauma
- Current use of certain blood thinners
- In those cases, we may consider **mechanical clot removal** (thrombectomy) or supportive care instead.

Summary for Patients/Caregivers

- This medication **breaks up the clot** causing your stroke.
- It is **very time-sensitive** — the earlier it's given, the better.
- The **main risk is bleeding**, which we will watch closely for.
- It is a **proven treatment** that helps many people recover better from stroke.

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